

Gendered Pragmatics in Marriage Negotiations among the Ejagham People: A Cultural Pragmatic Exploration

By

Takim Ajom Okongor (PhD)

Department of English and Linguistics

Faculty of Arts and Social Sciences

Federal University Dutse

Jigawa State

Email: takimajomokongor@gmail.com

08137945071

&

Chinyere Uchegbu- Ekwueme PhD

Department of English and Linguistics

Faculty of Arts and Social Sciences

Federal University Dutse

Jigawa State

Nigeria

Email: chi4c247@yahoo.com

08137509111

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Abstract

This study investigates gendered pragmatics in marriage negotiations among the Ejagham people, with attention to how communicative choices reflect cultural expectations and social roles. Although marriage negotiations are central to Ejagham identity, limited research has explored how gender shapes the language practices used in this context. The problem addressed in this work lies in the underrepresentation of indigenous perspectives on gendered communication, particularly within traditional African institutions such as marriage. Data were generated through oral performances, participant observation, semi-structured interviews, and analysis of naturally occurring negotiation dialogues. The study employed ethnographic methods to ensure cultural authenticity. The findings reveal that men and women adopt different pragmatic strategies – such as indirectness, honorifics, and metaphorical expressions – to assert authority, show respect, or maintain harmony, depending on their roles in the negotiation process. The study contributes to knowledge by

highlighting how gendered discourse not only sustains cultural continuity but also negotiates power and identity within the Ejagham community. It further demonstrates the relevance of pragmatic theory in understanding African sociocultural practices. Recommendations include incorporating indigenous pragmatic insights into intercultural communication research, promoting documentation of oral traditions, and encouraging further comparative studies between Ejagham and other African societies.

Introduction

Language serves as a central element of cultural practices, not only facilitating communication but also embodying the norms, values, and identities of a community. Ejagham, a language predominantly spoken in Cross River State of Nigeria and parts of Cameroon, is classified within the Bantoid branch of the Niger-Congo language family. Historically, it has functioned as a key medium of communication and cultural expression among the Ejagham people. The language exists in several dialectal forms, reflecting the geographic spread and internal diversity of its speakers. Over the years, Ejagham has undergone linguistic shifts influenced by neighbouring ethnic groups, as well as colonial and post-colonial contact, yet it continues to play a central role in maintaining the cultural identity and oral traditions of its communities. One of the most interesting subject in the globe is marriage. Marriage is the oldest human institution on earth.

Whether it is traditional, Christian, or Court marriage, it seems that marriage is the only rite or ceremony that engendered a home or a family. According to Bohannan (1954), "A wedding brings a new social institution-a new family-into existence". By means of marriage, the entire globe is being populated. Bohannan outlines how the Tiv classify possessions hierarchical spheres- subsistence goods, prestige objects and marriageable persons (that is wives and dependents). She explains that marriage is perceived as the most elevated form of personal investment, revealing cultural values that prioritize women and kinship over material wealth. In many ethnic groups including Ejagham people, the institution of marriage is prestigious. Marriage is a cultural embedded social institution that link families.

Marriage within African societies is not merely a personal affair between a man and a woman but a collective cultural institution that involves families, lineages, and communities. Among the Ejagham people of Cross River State,

Nigeria, marriage negotiations go beyond the exchange of bride wealth or the formalization of kinship ties. They are deeply pragmatic interactions in which words, gestures, and silences carry cultural weight. Negotiation sessions are not just about securing agreements; they are performances of tradition where gender roles, authority, and identity are enacted through communication. In this sense, language becomes a tool for both preserving heritage and regulating relationships.

Despite the cultural richness of Ejagham marriage practices, very little has been written about how gender influences communication within these negotiations. Most studies on African marriages tend to emphasize material exchanges, family structures, or ceremonial rites, while overlooking the subtle pragmatic processes that govern interaction. In Ejagham culture, men often dominate formal speech, while women, though central to the marriage arrangement, may be restricted to indirect roles. These gendered patterns are not accidental; they reflect wider cultural attitudes about authority, respect, and identity. The absence of focused research on this issue leaves a gap in our understanding of how language mediates gender relations within one of the most important cultural institutions.

This study therefore seeks to examine the gendered pragmatics of marriage negotiations among the Ejagham people, with the aim of showing how communication is structured by cultural expectations and gender roles. Specifically, it investigates the linguistic strategies employed during marriage dialogues, explores how authority is distributed between men and women, and identifies the cultural values that are reinforced through these interactions. By doing so, the study also assesses how these pragmatic encounters contribute to the survival of Ejagham traditions in the face of social change.

To achieve this aim, the study is guided by the following questions: What pragmatic strategies are employed in Ejagham marriage negotiations? How do gender roles influence participation and decision-making? In what ways does language reflect cultural values and ideologies in these contexts? And how does gendered communication contribute to the preservation of tradition?

The Importance of this inquiry lies in its contribution to both linguistic and cultural studies. It enriches pragmatic research by situating language use

within an indigenous African context, where meaning is inseparable from culture. It also provides fresh insights into how gender structures everyday communication, adding to debates on language, power, and cultural feminism. In African societies, marriage ceremonies are one of the most significant cultural institutions where language is deeply intertwined with social practices. The Ejagham people of Cross River State, Nigeria, are well known for their elaborate marital customs, where negotiations between families are conducted through culturally prescribed speech events. These negotiations are highly structured and laden with pragmatic cues that reflect both gender roles and cultural values.

Marriage negotiations within the Ejagham community are more than transactions; they are symbolic enactments of social order, lineage continuity, and gender relations. Men and women employ different linguistic strategies in these contexts. While men often assume directive and authoritative roles, women navigate the process through politeness, metaphor, and subtle forms of resistance. Baloyi (2022) emphasizes that marriage in many African societies is not merely a personal commitment but a collective cultural performance. As Baloyi observes, marriage to Ejagham people as with many African societies, does not only involve the husband and wife but serves as a link between both families. This study explores how pragmatic strategies shape gendered communication in Ejagham marriage negotiations, drawing attention to the cultural embedding of discourse practices.

Literature Review

Pragmatics is a branch of linguistics concerned with how language users convey and interpret meaning in real contexts of interaction. Unlike semantics, which emphasizes the literal meanings of words, pragmatics focuses on how meaning is shaped by the situation, participants, and cultural norms (Levinson, 1983; Mey, 2001). Scholars argue that communicative acts cannot be divorced from their social and cultural settings, since language functions not only as a tool for expression but also as a means of negotiating relationships, power, and identity (Thomas, 1995). This perspective is particularly useful for understanding traditional practices such as marriage negotiations, where words carry cultural weight beyond their surface meanings.

One central area of pragmatic inquiry is speech acts, which describe how utterances perform actions such as requesting, promising, or apologizing

(Austin, 1962; Searle, 1969). Within marriage negotiations, such acts may take the form of requests for bride wealth, expressions of gratitude, or indirect refusals. Politeness theory also provides insight, highlighting strategies speakers use to maintain respect and harmony in interaction (Brown & Levinson, 1987). In Ejagham culture, for instance, honorific expressions, indirectness, and metaphorical language are employed to uphold social decorum and reflect communal values during marital dialogue.

Gendered communication has long been a subject of scholarly interest. Research shows that men and women often adopt different pragmatic strategies shaped by cultural expectations (Tannen, 1990; Coates, 2015). Feminist linguistic studies argue that gender is not merely biological but socially constructed and enacted through discourse (Cameron, 1998). Emenike (2016), highlights how women are situated within African cultural settings, noting that the roles they assume in marriage mirror broader efforts to gain recognition, express their voices, and engage in negotiation. Her study highlights how patriarchal traditions often limit women's abilities, yet they still find subtle ways of asserting influence within negotiation spaces. Similarly, Obire (2018) also stresses women's quest for participation in decision-making processes, pointing out that language becomes a site where resistance and accommodation are enacted.

When viewed collectively, these perspectives suggest that marriage negotiations are far from neutral; rather, they function as communicative encounters where gendered power dynamics are continually reinforced or challenged. A Emenike (2016) and Obire (2018) suggest, studying gendered communication not only uncovers the subtle ways in which women navigate cultural structures but also opens space for rethinking how traditions can adapt while still retaining their identity. Considering these insights, women's voices in traditional settings are sometimes marginalized, while men occupy roles that reinforce authority and decision-making. However, feminist pragmatics emphasises that women also exercise agency by employing subtle strategies such as mitigation, indirection, and metaphor to influence outcomes (Bucholtz, 2014).

In the Ejagham context, marriage negotiation is not just a private affair but a public, communal event that reflects cultural norms of hierarchy, kinship, and

gendered roles. Men, often representing family authority, use direct speech and decision-oriented language, while women may employ supportive or indirect strategies that maintain harmony and respect. Yet, these differences do not indicate weakness on the part of women; rather, they reveal the pragmatic creativity through which women shape discourse within cultural constraints. Thus, applying a gendered pragmatic and feminist lens to Ejagham marriage negotiations demonstrates how communication both reflects and reshapes social structures.

Pragmatics reinforces the role of context in shaping meaning. Mey (2001) defines it as the study of how language users communicate in specific social settings, stressing that meaning cannot be separated from its cultural and social context. Marriage negotiations, therefore, represent a domain where meaning is highly situational and culturally coded.

Research on gendered discourse shows that men and women use language differently to construct identity and negotiate power. Tannen (1990) argues that male discourse stresses authority and independence, while female discourse privileges solidarity and politeness. Holmes (1995) expands this by highlighting women's use of politeness strategies to manage interpersonal relations.

In African contexts, scholars underline the cultural dimension of pragmatics. Nwoye (1992) explains that politeness in African societies often reflects collective values and emphasizes respect and harmony. Oha (1998) examines Igbo proverbs, showing how they reinforce female subordination within marital discourse. Adegbija (1994) stresses that African communicative events often reveal pragmatic force embedded in social hierarchies. This assertion is also supported by Ejagham marriage negotiations where modes of communication frequently reflect underlying pragmatic intent shaped by social hierarchies, revealing how power dynamics and social roles are embedded within everyday language use.

Okon (2010) explored Efik marriage negotiations and noted that ritualized exchanges, proverbs, and honorifics uphold gender roles and social order. This is also applicable to Ejagham people where marriage discussions often involve formal exchanges, traditional sayings, and respectful language that reinforce

established gender roles and maintain societal structure. Akinwotu (2015) studied Yoruba marriage negotiations, observing how humor, metaphor, and politeness strategies manage potential conflict. This perspective was also observed in Ejagham marriage negotiation where humor, metaphor, and polite communication are used to navigate and reduce potential conflict. Similarly, Obeng (2001) analyzed Akan communicative events, finding that indirectness often functions to maintain respect while subtly negotiating power. This finding was also noticed in Ejagham negotiation that indirectness in speech frequently operates as a strategy to preserve interpersonal respect, while also facilitating the complex negotiation of hierarchical power structures.

Despite these studies, limited attention has been given to the Ejagham community, whose marital negotiations exhibit distinctive pragmatic strategies and gendered communicative roles. This research fills that gap.

Methodology

Theoretical Framework

This research adopts cultural pragmatics (Mey, 2001) as its primary theoretical lens. Cultural Pragmatics points out the role of context in shaping meaning. Mey (2001) defines it as the study of how language users communicate in specific social settings, stressing that meaning cannot be separated from its cultural and social context. This work examines the ways people use language in particular social situations, emphasising that meaning is always tied to the cultural and social environment in which communication takes place. Pragmatics stresses the role of culture in shaping pragmatic meaning, recognizing that speech acts are interpreted within the cultural values of a society. It further integrates insights from gendered pragmatics (Eckert & McConnell-Ginet, 2003), which investigates how gender identities are constructed, reinforced, and contested through discourse.

By combining these frameworks, the study examines how the Ejagham's cultural traditions guide speech during marriage negotiations, while also considering how men and women draw upon gendered communicative norms to perform and negotiate their roles.

Sources of Data

The data for this study were collected from multiple sources:

1. Oral performances: Recordings and transcriptions of actual marriage

negotiations among Ejagham families, focusing on the language of both male and female participants.

2. Interviews: Semi-structured interviews with elders, negotiators, and women involved in marital negotiations, designed to capture their perspectives on communicative practices.

3. Cultural narratives and proverbs: Collection of Ejagham proverbs and narratives relevant to marriage, which often encode gender expectations.

Method of Data Collection

The study employed ethnographic methods to ensure cultural authenticity. Participant observation was conducted during five marriage negotiations across different Ejagham communities. These sessions were audio-recorded with consent and later transcribed. Semi-structured interviews were conducted with twenty participants, including elders, negotiators, and women married within the community. Interviews were conducted in both Ejagham and English, with translations cross-checked by bilingual speakers. Supplementary data were obtained from community elders who shared proverbs and oral traditions.

Method of Data Analysis

Data were analysed using a qualitative pragmatic approach. The transcribed negotiations were examined for recurrent speech acts such as requests, refusals, offers, greetings, and blessings. Special attention was given to politeness strategies, indirectness, and metaphorical language. The analysis also identified how men and women differently employed these strategies, linking them to broader cultural expectations. Interpretive analysis ensured that findings were grounded in Ejagham cultural norms rather than external frameworks.

Results/Findings

The analysis revealed that men dominate speech roles during negotiations, often speaking on behalf of the family and using directive speech acts to establish authority. For instance, in one setting, the groom's family visits the bride's family with drinks and gifts. Elders, relatives, and community members are present.

Sample Dialogue of Ejagham Marriage Negotiation Setting:
Groom's Representative (Ejagham):

“Nda mboh mb□η, anyi akpambe ofi a ndun.”

English: “We greet you elders, we have come with respect.”

Bride's Elder (Ejagham):

“Nda mboh. Nya anyu se akpambe, m□f□ eyen nkai ayu kpa?”

English: “We greet you too. You say you have come – what is your mission today?”

Groom's Representative (Ejagham):

“Nkene ekpeme be nson, anyi asua se nkai, mfen ndip eyo anyu?”

English: “We bring drinks and gifts. We love your daughter; may we have your blessing?”

Bride's Elder (Ejagham):

“Nyu ke ndip, nyu nkai obut nd□k. Obut kpan ay□ ma anyi?”

English: “You have come well, but our daughter is precious. What have you brought to honor our home?”

Groom's Elder (Ejagham):

“Mboh, abasi ndip. Ofi anyi obut nt□, ma anyi ayak eyen anyu ke mfin.”

English: “Elders, forgive us. What we bring is small, but we promise your daughter will be cared for.”

Bride's Elder (Ejagham):

“Obut ayu abet. Eyen anyi obut nd□k. Ma se ndun, nyu ekpeme eyen anyi.”

English: “Your words are good. Our daughter is precious, but since you have spoken with respect, we give her to you.”

Community Elder (Ejagham):

“Nda mboh, obut ayu. Nyu kpeme ke eyen anyi, nyu se nd□η ke nd□η.”

English: “Elders, it is well. You take our daughter; may there be peace between the families.”

Groom's Family (Chorus – Ejagham):

“Mboh! Ma nd□η! Anyi eyen nkai, nyu eyen anyi.”

English: “Thank you! Let there be peace! Your daughter is now our daughter.”

In another negotiation, a male elder declared: “We are here to take the daughter of this house as our wife. We have come with respect, but also with purpose.”

This type of authoritative tone underscores men's leading role. Women, in contrast, were less vocal in public sessions but exercised influence through indirect strategies such as humor, silence, and metaphor.

Politeness emerged as a key pragmatic strategy. Women were expected to demonstrate humility and respect through deferential language. In one

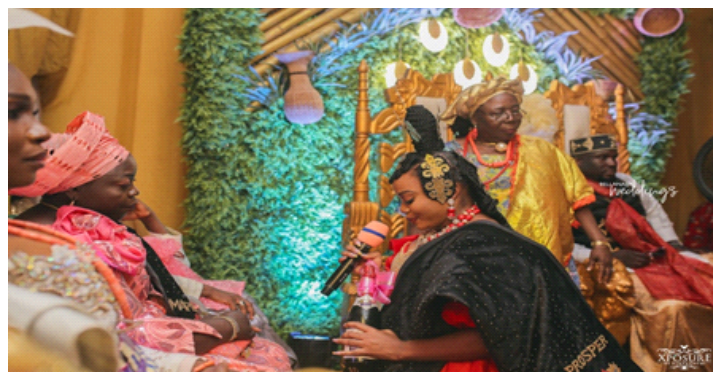
exchange, a bride's aunt remarked: "Our daughter is still young in our hands, treat her gently as the kola nut is handled." Such metaphors carry both politeness and cultural symbolism. Men also employed honorifics and formal greetings to uphold dignity, signaling mutual respect despite underlying negotiation.

Ejagham proverbs and metaphors played a central role in negotiations, often reinforcing gender roles. For example, women were described as "the pillar of the home," stressing domestic responsibility, while men were framed as "the roof that shelters the family," highlighting authority and provision. Proverbs thus served as culturally coded tools for reinforcing normative expectations while embedding the discourse in tradition.

Despite the apparent dominance of men, women employed subtle resistance strategies. Some used irony or rhetorical questions to challenge male authority without openly disrupting the process. For example, during one negotiation, a woman quipped: "Is the groom strong enough to carry both the wife and the debts he owes?". This remark, though humorous, implicitly questioned the groom's readiness, showing how women could assert influence within culturally acceptable boundary.

Beyond academic relevance, the study serves a documentary purpose by recording practices that younger Ejagham generations may be less familiar with, especially in an era of globalization where many traditions face erosion. For cultural custodians and educators, the findings will be useful in promoting awareness of how language functions as a carrier of cultural identity.

Picture 1: Ejagham marriage negotiation adopted online



Picture 2: Ejagham elders after negotiation



Picture 3: Ejagham bride during celebration



Conclusion

The study demonstrates that Ejagham marriage negotiations are deeply gendered communicative events where pragmatic strategies reflect cultural norms and power relations. Men typically dominate the discourse, using directive speech acts, while women adopt indirect strategies that reflect respect and politeness but also offer subtle resistance. Proverbs and metaphors reinforce traditional roles but also allow for negotiation of identity and power. By situating marriage discourse within the framework of cultural pragmatics, this research underscores how language both reflects and shapes gender roles in African cultural institutions. The findings have broader implications for

understanding the interplay between language, gender, and culture in African contexts. They suggest that marriage negotiations serve as microcosms of wider gender relations, highlighting both the resilience of tradition and the subtle ways in which women negotiate agency within it.

This research underscores the value of cultural pragmatics in analyzing African communicative practices, showing how language functions not only as a tool of communication but as a medium of cultural reproduction and gender negotiation.

Recommendations:

There should be intentional efforts by community elders and cultural institutions to educate the younger generation about the importance of traditional marriage customs.

Schools and local institutions can incorporate aspects of indigenous marriage rites into cultural studies curricula to promote awareness and respect.

Government and cultural preservation bodies should support initiatives aimed at documenting and promoting Ejagham marriage practices through media, publications, and events.

Collaboration between traditional leaders and religious figures could help bridge understanding and foster mutual respect between cultural practices and religious values.

Statements and Declarations

The authors declare that this work is original, has not been published elsewhere. It involves no conflicts of interest, received no external funding, and complies with all ethical standards.

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